

Women's Health Research (1)

Workflow State: Agency Entry

Last Updated: 04/10/2024 02:29:28 PM

Women's Health Research Topline Total (DATA INPUT)

Office	Activity/Program	FY2023 Actual	FY2025 PB
VA	ORD	40	29

Women's Health Research Topline Total (Narrative)

The Department of Veterans Affairs (VA), Office of Research and Development (ORD) funds a robust women's health and healthcare research program, including biomedical, clinical, rehabilitation, genomic, health systems, data science and implementation research. Annual funding amount is based on meritorious applications determined by a scientific peer-review process and draws from the overall research appropriation; ORD does not allocate set amounts of its appropriation for women's health research. Women's health is a priority area in VA's Request for Applications (RFAs). The majority of women's health research projects are based on investigator-initiated applications. Project tracking is done using VA financial system (Research Analysis Forecasting Tool (RAFT)).

The FY2023 actuals and FY2025 estimates presented are for projects across the scientific disciplines funded by the Medical and Prosthetics Research appropriation. FY2025 estimates are based on the FY2023 actuals plus known plans. New project funding cannot be forecasted, because it is subject to availability and is based on investigator-initiated applications that will undergo the scientific peer-review process. Numbers are reported in millions.

Women's Health Research Totals by Condition (DATA INPUT)

Research Area	Office	Activity/Program	FY2023 Actual	FY2025 PB
Endometriosis and Fibroids	VA	ORD	0	0
Alzheimer's Disease	VA	ORD	0	0
Autoimmune Diseases	VA	ORD	4	4
Menopause	VA	ORD	1	1
Cardiovascular Disease	VA	ORD	4	3
	VA	ORD	31	22

Narrative

Numbers are reported in millions. FY23 funding showing \$0 is due to rounding to millions; VA is currently funding research in all conditions specified. After we identified which projects were women's health projects, we then separated those into condition specific totals. To do this, we relied on coding in our VA financial system (Research Analysis Forecasting Tool (RAFT) and by searching titles and abstracts when existing codes were not available. More specifically:

- **Autoimmune diseases.** This is based on our Designated Research Area of Autoimmunity, Allergy, and Immunology. This code is used for proposals which focus on the etiology, pathogenesis, epidemiology, diagnosis, treatment, prevention, healthcare utilization, and delivery of care for autoimmune diseases, immunodeficiency, immune-complex disorders, and diseases related to allergic or delayed hypersensitivity reactions and the effects of aging on these functions. Include Lupus, cells of the immune system, immunology of organ transplantation.
- **Menopause and Perimenopause.** We do not have an existing code, so we searched all project titles and abstracts for the following key terms "menopause" or "perimenopause."
- **Cardiovascular Disease.** This is based on our Designated Research Area of Cardiovascular Disease. This code is used for proposals which focus on the etiology, pathogenesis, epidemiology, diagnosis, treatment, prevention, healthcare utilization, and delivery of care for diseases and disorders of the heart, central and peripheral vasculature, and cellular and non-cellular constituents of blood. Include studies on idiopathic hypertension, stroke, hemostasis, thrombosis, blood coagulation, hematopoiesis, anemia, pacemakers, and defibrillators.
- **Endometriosis and Fibroids.** We do not have an existing code, so we searched all project titles and abstracts for the following key terms "endometriosis" and "fibroid."
- **Alzheimer's Disease.** This is based on our Research Priority Area code for Alzheimer's Disease. VA Research on Alzheimer's Disease (AD) includes studies on: (1) elucidating the underlying molecular and/or genetic causes of AD; (2) early diagnosis and detection of AD; (3) potential targets for slowing the progression of the disease; (4) the discovery of novel chemical or biological therapies for AD; (5) physical and mental rehabilitation programs for Veterans suffering from AD; and (6) health care programs for caregivers.
- Other (shown as blank in the table above) includes projects focused on any topic not included in the requested categories. Projects can be included in more than one of the specified categories (i.e., the sum of the sub-categories is more than the FY23 total due to project overlap).

Below are obligations in whole dollars for further detail:

Research Area	Office	Activity/Program	FY2023 Actual	FY2025 PB
Endometriosis and Fibroids	VA	ORD	117,000	0

Alzheimer's Disease	VA	ORD	302,000	302,000
Autoimmune Diseases ¹	VA	ORD	4,462,000	3,551,000
Menopause and Perimenopause	VA	ORD	1,397,000	725,000
Cardiovascular Disease	VA	ORD	3,672,000	3,241,000
Other ²	VA	ORD	31,412,000	22,382,000
Notes:				

1. Autoimmune diseases includes projects focused on autoimmunity, allergy and inflammation (per VA category definition).

2. Other includes projects focused on any topic not included in the requested categories. Projects can be included in more than one of the specified categories (i.e., the sum of the sub-categories is more than the FY23 total due to project overlap).

Narrative

VA Women's Health Infrastructure Support

In addition to funding many critical women's health research projects, VA funds the [Women's Health Research Network \(WHRN\)](#), which is a special initiative to systematically transform VA's capacity to examine and reduce gender disparities in health and health care and use research to increase the delivery of evidence-based care tailored to women Veterans' needs. The national VA WHRN has helped build VA women's health services research capacity. It is responsive to and partners with health system leaders including the VHA Office of Women's Health, frontline staff, and women Veterans. VA has also been working to bolster recruitment of women by specifically focusing on understanding and overcoming barriers specific to women's participation in VA clinical trials through the [Women's Enhanced Recruitment Program \(WERP\)](#). When applicable, WERP also provides tools to help investigators and Veterans understand biological and gender-based needs in clinical research. As part of the VA's recommendations for the White House Women's Health Research Initiative, VA is exploring how it might expand these infrastructure supports more broadly across the research enterprise.

Understanding Women Veteran Population

Women Veterans are entering the military at unprecedented rates, forever changing the demographics of the Veterans served and the range of services VA providers must be prepared to deliver. Women Veterans who use the VA are as complex medically as their male counterparts, even though they are on average 10 years younger. Women Veterans present with more mental health-related multi-morbidities, in part due to much higher rates of military sexual trauma (MST) and other mental health disorders. The need to deliver gender-specific care (e.g., reproductive health services) and care for conditions of higher prevalence (e.g., osteoporosis, depression) or with different clinical presentations (e.g., heart disease, chronic pain) among women also imposes

considerable training and experiential requirements on a VA workforce with historically limited exposure to women patients. Women face additional barriers (e.g., harassment, lack of gender sensitivity) which can lead to attrition and discontinuity of care or seeking community or other non-VA care at higher rates. Women Veterans also need medical equipment and components designed and tailored to them, including prosthetic components.

VA ORD's women's health and healthcare research is responsive to the changing needs and demographics of women Veterans to provide them with the best care possible.

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